

The Historicity of the Flood Narrative

We have substantial reason to think that the flood narrative is rooted in ancient Mesopotamian tradition and originates from a real, catastrophic flood during the prehistoric period (namely, before the advent of history writing during the early empires of Sumer and Akkad).

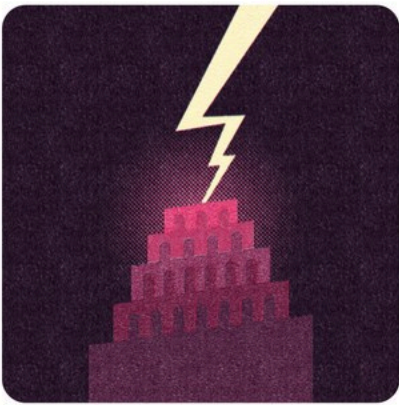
All the flood accounts from Mesopotamia clearly belong to the same general family of traditions that go back beyond the year 2,000 B.C.E. Also, Mesopotamia is a huge flood plain where two large regional rivers merge together.

There is also evidence of occasional catastrophic floods. In the work of William Ryan and Walter Pitman (*Noah's Flood: The New Scientific Discoveries About an Event That Changed History*, 2000), they describe a flood that would date to around 5,600 B.C.E. that explains the geological shape of the divide between eastern Europe and Anatolia (modern day Turkey) and the origins of the Black Sea.

We can clearly see that the biblical flood narrative has been adopted from a Mesopotamian tradition of the flood story and adapted for the theological purposes of the authors.

Reflection Question

What is the significance of the biblical authors' use of flood language in other stories later in the Bible?



Module 6: The Cycle Begins Again

SESSIONS 23-28

Follow the stories about Noah's sons, the origins of the nations, and the founding of Babylon as the pattern is replayed, nuanced, and intensified.

Session 23: God's Covenant With Noah

Key Takeaways

- Noah's drunkenness recalls the foolish failure of the man and woman in the garden of Eden.
- Ham's crime against his family recalls both the failure of Genesis 3 and the escalation of Genesis 4.
- Ham's crime against his family was some form of illicit sexual abuse. The maternal incest (i.e., rape) interpretation of Ham's sin accounts for both the severity of Noah's response and the curse on Canaan.

Noah's Garden and a Family Failure: Translation and Literary Design of Genesis 9:18-29

Noah's Sons: Shem, Ham (= Canaan), and Japheth

- ¹⁸ And the sons of Noah who came out of the ark were **Shem** and **Ham** and **Japheth**; and **Ham was the father of Canaan**.
- ¹⁹ These three were the sons of Noah, and from these all the land was scattered.

Noah

- ²⁰ **And Noah** began to be a man of the ground and he planted a vineyard;
- ²¹ **and he drank of the wine and became drunk**, and he uncovered himself in the middle of his tent.

Noah's Sons: Ham (= Canaan), Shem and Japheth

- a ²² And **Ham, the father of Canaan**,
- b **saw the nakedness of his father**,
- a and he reported to **his two brothers** outside.
- b ²³ And **Shem** and **Japheth** took a garment
- a' and they laid it upon the shoulders of **the two of them**,
- a and they walked **backward**

- b and they **covered the nakedness of their father** ;
a' and their faces were **backward** ,
b' and the **nakedness of their father they did not see** .

Noah

- 24 **And Noah awoke from his wine** ,
and he knew what his younger son had done to him;

Noah's Sons: Ham (= Canaan), Shem, and Japheth

- 25 and he said,
a "Cursed be **Canaan** ;
b a servant of servants he will be to his brothers."
- 26 And he said,
a "Blessed be Yahweh the Elohim of **Shem** ,
b and let **Canaan** be his servant."
- a 27 May Elohim enlarge **Japheth** ,
a and let him dwell in the tents of **Shem** ,
b and let **Canaan** be his servant."

Noah

- 28 **And Noah** lived, after the flood, three hundred and fifty years.
29 And all the days of Noah were nine hundred and fifty years,
and he died.

Genesis 9:18-29. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Adam to Noah (2020).

Notice the alternating panels going back and forth between the actions and life of Noah and the actions and future destiny of his sons.

The focus on Ham is in reality a focus on Ham's son Canaan, a connection that will be unpacked only in the following chapter (see Gen. 10:6). It's as if Ham's actions toward his father are an archetype of his descendants' behavior (see Lev. 18 and Lev. 20).

Noah's Three Scattered Sons (Gen. 9:18-19)

The author draws attention to the brothers coming out of the ark as one family, yet after leaving the ark, they are divided and scattered (just as Cain and Abel/Seth left Eden and were divided).

The link between the division of Cain and Abel/Seth and the division of Noah’s sons is reinforced by the intentional parallelism between the line of Cain leading to Lemek and his three sons in Genesis 4:17-26 and the line of Seth leading to Noah and his three sons in Genesis 5:1-32 and 9:18-19.

Cain’s Line Leads to the Flood	Seth’s Line Leads to the Scattering of Babylon
1. Adam 2. Cain 3. Enoch 4. Lyrad 5. Mehuya’el 6. Methusha’el 7. Lemek + 3 sons □ Yabal □ Yubal □ Tubal-Cain	1. Adam 2. Seth 3. Enosh 4. Cainan 5. Mahalelel 6. Yered 7. Enoch 8. Methushelah 9. Lemek 10. Noah + 3 sons □ Shem □ Ham □ Japheth
“Yabal, the father of (אבי) tent-dwellers and livestock” (Gen. 4:20) “Yubal, the father of (אבי) all handlers of lyre and flute” (Gen 4:21)	“Ham, the father of (אבי) Canaan” (Gen. 9:18) “Ham, the father of (אבי) Canaan” (Gen. 9:22)
Followed by the episode about sons of God and human women (Gen. 6:1-4)	Followed by the episode about Ham exploiting his father’s nakedness (Gen. 9:21-24)
... resulting in the flood (<i>mabbul</i> / מבוֹל)	... resulting in a curse, that will lead to the scattering of Babylon (<i>babel</i> / בבל)
<i>Noah’s Three Scattered Sons. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Noah to Abraham (2020).</i>	

The mention of “scattering” in Genesis 9:19 is the first use of a key word-matrix: *naphats* (נפץ) and *puts* (פוץ). These are among the standard words used later in the Prophets to describe Israel’s exile among the nations, out of which a remnant (like Noah) will return to Zion.

Isaiah 11:11-12 NASB*

¹¹ Then it will happen on that day that the Lord will again recover the second time with his hand, the remnant of his people who will remain, from Assyria, Egypt, Pathros, Cush, Elam, Shinar, Hamath, and from the islands of the sea.

¹² And he will lift up a standard for the nations